

The interview that finds the person, and the first month that keeps children safe.

Schedule 2 of the Children's Homes Regulations lists what every staff file must hold, and one line in it is the interview: who interviewed, when, and the judgment reached. This page is the interview worth recording, then the first month.

The interview: questions that find the person

Before anyone speaks

Two people on the panel, one of them trained in safer recruitment. The application form in front of you with every job dated month and year, because the form is where the gaps show and the interview is where they get explained.

Values and judgment

"Why do you want to work with these children, and what do you think the hardest part will be?"

"Tell me about a time a child or young person was angry with you. What did you do, and what did you feel?"

"Describe a boundary you found hard to hold. What did you do?"

"What would you do if you saw a colleague do something you thought was wrong? Would you tell someone outside the home, and who?"

"A child tells you something and asks you to keep it a secret. What do you say?"

"What does good recording look like at the end of a shift?"

The three probes, every time

Every gap. Go through the form month by month. Anything over a month gets the question, "What was that period?", and the answer gets written down. Written down is a pass; silence in the file is a finding.

Every ending. "Why did that job end?" Then, "Would your last manager say the same?" Reasons that shift under the second question are the ones to check in the reference call.

Work with children or vulnerable adults that ended. Schedule 2 asks you to check, as far as practicable, why any such work ended. Ask it directly and write the answer.

The disclosure question

This role is regulated activity, so you may ask: "Is there anything in your past, spent or not, that could come up on an enhanced DBS check or in a reference that we should hear from you first?" Say why you ask. A calm, complete answer is a good sign.

What goes in the file

The date, who interviewed, the questions asked, a summary of the answers, the judgment and the reasons for it, signed by the panel. Plus the written gap explanations, and the reference verification notes when the calls are made. That is the interview record Schedule 2 means.

Signs worth a second look

Reluctance or vagueness about a gap, or a different reason each time it comes up.

Every previous employer was the problem.

No reflection on boundaries, or an answer about boundaries that is all about the adult's feelings.

Over-interest in a particular child, age group or in being alone with children.

A reference from a mobile number or a friend rather than the organisation.

None of these decides anything on its own. Each one is a reason to ask one more question and to make the reference call to the main switchboard.

The first month: the induction checklist

One copy per new starter, in the file. Regulation 32 asks that staff get the induction, training and supervision the role needs; this is the list that proves it. Tick, date and initial each line.

Before the first shift with children

- ☐ Enhanced DBS with barred list check received and recorded (number and date only); Update Service consent noted.
- ☐ References received and verified by phone, with the notes in the file.
- ☐ Safeguarding policy read and signed. The designated officer (LADO) named, with the number.
- ☐ Whistleblowing: who they can go to, inside and outside the home (RI, LADO, Ofsted), in writing.
- ☐ Missing child protocol read, and each child's own missing plan.
- ☐ Behaviour support and restraint policy read. No restraint until trained and signed off.
- ☐ Medication policy read. No administering until trained and competency assessed.
- ☐ Each child's placement plan and risk assessment read and discussed with the key worker.
- ☐ Fire procedure, health and safety, lone working, and the building walk round.
- ☐ Recording standards: daily logs, incident reports, what to write and by when.
- ☐ Confidentiality and data protection, and what never leaves the home.
- ☐ Complaints procedure, including how a child makes one.

In the first month

- ☐ Shadow shifts completed (number agreed and recorded).
- ☐ First supervision held within two weeks, recorded on the supervision record.
- ☐ Probation review date set and in the diary.
- ☐ Level 3 diploma: enrolment date agreed and on the Staff list tab.
- ☐ Mandatory training booked: safeguarding, first aid, fire, medication, physical intervention.
- ☐ Introduced to the independent visitor and told what the regulation 44 visit is for.

New starter _____

Manager _____

Induction completed on _____